memoir of great sensitivity and wit, demonstrating a curious mind and a fascination with the natural world.

A few months before the formal start of their education, the circumcision ceremony of the young princes had been carried out in equally grandiose style. As Akbar built his new capital at Fatehpur, he was careful to place his sons in the midst of the imperial image-building, thereby binding the allegiance of the noblemen to his heirs. However, as scholar Munis Faruqui has shown, the dangerous old Timurid system of appanages for princes was quietly abandoned. Now contenders for the throne could only arise from among the Padshah's own sons. Moreover, the new system was designed in such a way that princes were expected to work tirelessly at cultivating their networks of influential noblemen so that when the time came for them to stake their claim to rule, they would be ready. As we shall see later in the book, this system was not without its disadvantages and imperfections but it would safeguard the empire against fragmentation upon the death of a Padshah.

'The wise sovereign,' noted Abu'l Fazl approvingly, 'kept his children under his own care and did not appoint any guardian to them, and was continually educating them in the most excellent manner of which there are few instances in ancient times. Their holy minds have been enlightened daily by the sciences.' Akbar did appoint ataliqs to the princes but these men were inextricably bound to the Padshah through ancient ties of loyalty. In 1577, Akbar appointed Shaikh Ahmad, one of Shaikh Salim Chishti's sons, to be tutor to Prince Salim and many of the Shaikh's family members now lived in the prince's household, as milk mothers, kokas, tutors, and imperial officers. The daughter of Shaikh Salim Chishti was a beloved milk mother and, when he became emperor, Jahangir would write about this woman that 'I have not so much affection for my own mother as for her. She is to me my gracious mother.' Akbar would also take Salim, from the time he was a baby, to be presented at the dargah of Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti, thus aligning the prince's fate with that of this Hindustani order of saints. It would have been a silently eloquent symbol for Salim, a Mughal prince born to a Rajput mother, to be seen in the strategically important site of Ajmer in Rajasthan.

In 1579, when Salim was ten, Akbar appointed a member of his own Ataka clan, Qutbuddin Khan, brother of Shamsuddin Ataka Khan, as ataliq to the prince. Another Ataka clan member, Sharif Khan, was appointed tutor